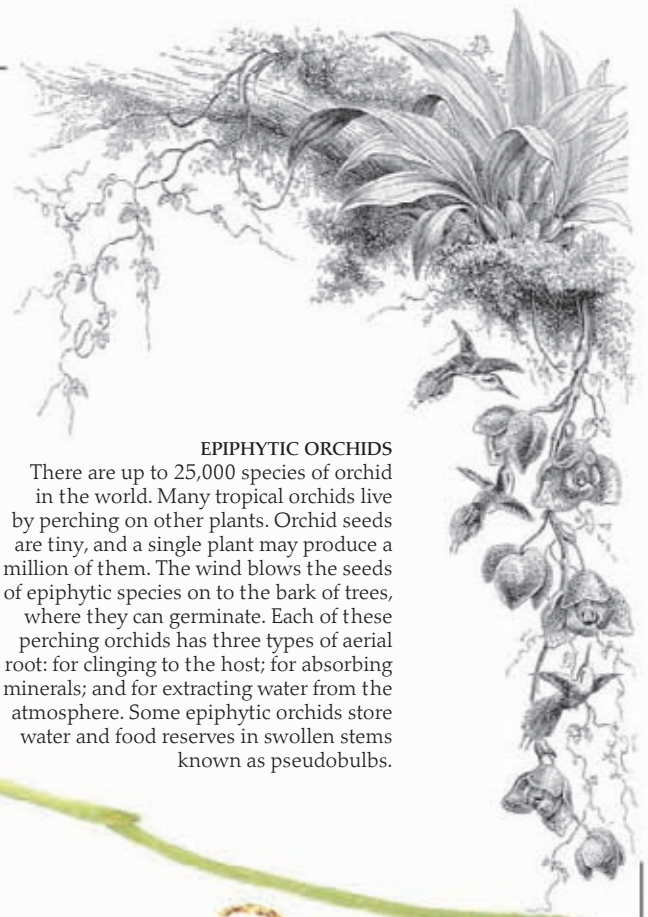




A species of moth orchid



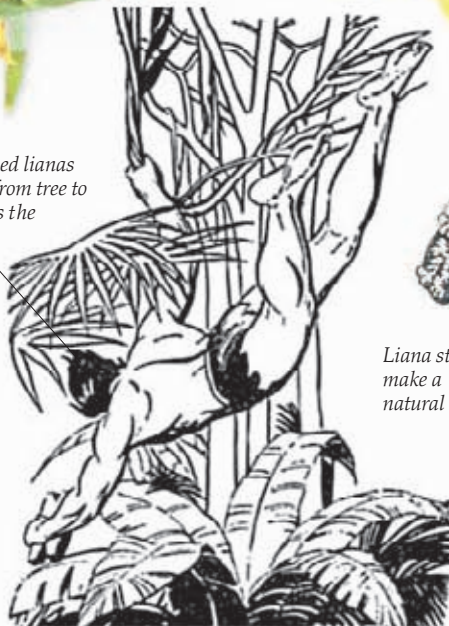
EPIPHYTIC ORCHIDS

There are up to 25,000 species of orchid in the world. Many tropical orchids live by perching on other plants. Orchid seeds are tiny, and a single plant may produce a million of them. The wind blows the seeds of epiphytic species on to the bark of trees, where they can germinate. Each of these perching orchids has three types of aerial root: for clinging to the host; for absorbing minerals; and for extracting water from the atmosphere. Some epiphytic orchids store water and food reserves in swollen stems known as pseudobulbs.

Flowers produce minutes seeds to be dispersed by wind

Thick, trailing aerial roots collect moisture as well as minerals from trickling rainwater

Tarzan used lianas to swing from tree to tree across the jungle



Liana stems make a natural rope



Entwined liana stems

NATURAL ROPES

Lianas are climbing plants with flexible woody stems. Sometimes they twine around each other for mutual support. If the original support dies and decays, the lianas are left suspended from the forest canopy. Other plants, called stranglers, start life above ground and then grow roots downward. Their roots form a mesh around the trunks of trees and eventually kill the support.

Tarzan, a fictional hero of books, movies, and comics